

Lesson 9

Allowing (Part 1) - Putting Down the Physical Fight

Before we get into allowing, I want to make the distinction between acceptance and allowing. Really clear acceptance is putting down the mental fight. It's the resistance to your situation at large. Acceptance is about your relationship to the broader picture of where you are in your life and what you're dealing with in this situation.

That's what we covered in the last two lessons. Allowing is different. Allowing is about right now. This moment. What's happening in your body in this moment? Allowing is your relationship to your experience, your sensations, your symptoms, the physical experience of being in a body that is going through this.

So when a sensation shows up, be it pain, tightness, dizziness, nausea, anxiety, the pit in your stomach, whatever it is for you, there's usually an automatic response. Your body is going to brace against it. Everything will clench up. You get tense. You hold your breath. It's like you're trying to push the sensation away, make it stop, or just survive it until it passes.

And underneath that bracing is a belief that it should not be here, that it's bad, that it's here, that it's terrifying, that it's showing up. Allowing is the opposite of all of that. Allowing is letting whatever you're feeling in your body actually be there is almost like you're making room for it.

You're dropping the resistance to its presence. It's like the sensation is here. It's allowed to be here. I don't have to make it go away right now, and I do wanna be very clear about what allowing is, not just because a lot of people get this wrong, including myself for a very long time. Allowing is not the same thing as ignoring how you feel.

It's not suppressing your symptoms or pushing them down. It's not pretending that you're fine when you clearly are not. It's not white knuckling your way through the day. While internally, you're still just fighting with everything that you're feeling. If it feels like you're forcing it, you are not actually allowing.

When I first learned about allowing, I thought I was doing it right. Because I was going about my life. I was functioning. I had symptoms, and I was still doing things. So I figured I must be allowing, right? But what I was actually doing was ignoring my symptoms to the best of my ability, pushing them down, going through the motions.

Getting stuff done. But yeah, I was pushing everything. I was feeling down and away from myself. Mentally. I was still fighting my situation, so I obviously wasn't in acceptance, but physically I was bracing against every sensation. So technically I wasn't allowing either. I was just surviving the day and calling that allowing.

But as I've said again and again, my body knew the difference. I was still clenched, still really holding my breath, breathing from my chest, and treating every sensation and symptom like a threat I didn't have to fix, but that I had to endure. Real allowing is different. It feels different. It means that the sensations are there and you're actually letting them be there.

You are not pushing them away. You're not pretending that they're not happening, but you're also not waiting for them to pass so that then you can relax, then you can do something. Then you'll be okay. You're making room for them while they're present. You are living alongside them instead of against them.

Allowing is really more about building a new relationship with your symptoms. Think about the relationship you have with your symptoms right now. For most people, it's the enemy. The symptoms are the enemy because when they show up, there is terror, dread, disdain, hatred, panic. It's just like, not this, again, I cannot handle this.

Make it stop. Of course, that reaction is completely understandable. You've been suffering, of course, you hate what you're feeling, and of course you want it gone. But that relationship, the terror and hatred and bracing. Is a huge part of what keeps the alarm running because your nervous system is reading your response to the sensations, and when you respond with that fear and resistance and that feeling and belief that this has to stop, what you're doing innocently is confirming that these sensations are dangerous.

You're actively teaching your nervous system to keep sounding that alarm. Allowing is about shifting that relationship, not like instantly, but moving in a different direction. So I really do see this as a spectrum. On one end of the spectrum is where most people start, especially when they're unfamiliar with, with what they're experiencing with is terror.

It is dread. It's, I cannot stand this. I need it to stop. And then you have the polar opposite end, which would be like, this is totally fine. This doesn't bother me at all. Yeah, go ahead. Come on in. You don't need to get all the way to that other end. It's not realistic and I'm really not asking for that.

But the goal is to move somewhere more toward the middle. Toward neutrality toward, this is here, I don't like it, but I'm not gonna spend all my energy fighting it right now towards something like familiarity. And when you've been terrified of your symptoms for so long, they stay unfamiliar, like they stay scary because every time they show up, it's like a new threat appearing.

But when you start to allow them and you stop running. And bracing and treating them like a brand new emergency. You start to get familiar with them. You start to get to know them. You start to notice, oh, this is what this feels like. This is what it does. It spikes, it peaks, it settles, it moves around.

It's uncomfortable, but it's not actually hurting me. I've felt this before. Like I know this one. Something important is that painful is not the same as dangerous and terrifying is not the same as an emergency. Your nervous system has got these wires crossed. It's reading sensations and symptoms as threats.

It's sounding the alarm on things that are uncomfortable, very, very uncomfortable, but not actually harmful. That's what sensitization does. It's the worst. It turns the volume up on everything until a normal sensation feels like an absolute crisis. The same as the way you experience your symptoms. It feels like an emergency.

It feels like something must be wrong because our brain is using that ability to signal that we need to look at something, which in a nonsensitized person is a very, very helpful function of the brain. In your situation, the sensitization means we can't trust those alerts from our nervous system. Just because something feels completely unbearable doesn't mean that it is.

Just because your body is screaming that there's danger does not mean that you are actually in danger. The sensations you're experiencing are real. The suffering is real, but the emergency aspect of it is not. This is so hard to remember when you're in the middle of it. When your heart is pounding and your head is spinning and every part of you is saying this is, there's obviously something wrong here.

It does not feel like a false alarm. It feels like the realest alarm you've ever felt, the most real thing in the world. But your nervous system is not a reliable narrator right now. It's sensitized, it's overreading threat, and part of allowing is doing your best to start to see that very clearly. Oh, this feels dangerous, but it's not.

This is my nervous system doing its thing. This is uncomfortable, but it's not unsafe. And that is the shift from like these symptoms and sensations are a stranger to me, and they are a threat to something you recognize even when new things show up because you know what a sensitized nervous system does and you realize this is something that I can coexist with.

I am not asking you to love your symptoms. I'm not asking you to be grateful for them or pretend that they're fine. I'm asking you to stop being at war with them. You don't have to love what you're feeling, but you do have to stop fighting it so hard. When your symptoms show up and your body starts to brace and everything tightens and you hold your breath and you clench, allowing is the physical softening.

It's noticing that you're, you're preparing to fight. Your body is literally preparing to fight, and you release it on purpose. This is not forcing yourself to feel relaxed. You're not gonna be even close to that. It's just letting go of that grip a little bit. Learning to let the sensation be there without clenching around it.

And this is literally what I mean when I say softening throughout this course. It's that physical release. You notice I'm clenching my jaw and you let it go. You notice your shoulders are up by your ears and

you drop them. Your stomach is tight and you stop holding it. Your breath is shallow and you let it deepen.

This is not a breathing exercise. This is not a technique. This is just a choice to notice what's in your body and soften a little bit. You do not have the power to make sensations go away. I know you want that power. I want that power too. But the fact of the matter is that they are here. They're going to be here whether you fight them or not, you can clench against them and brace against them, and they're still gonna be there.

You can panic and they're still gonna be there. You can hate them with everything you have. They are still going to be there. So if the sensation is gonna be there either way, why not choose the response that actually unwire this? Why not choose the response that teaches your nervous system? Something new, the sensation stays, you soften around it.

That's allowing. Allowing also applies to the thoughts that spike in the moment, so not the resistance thoughts to your situation. We covered those already with acceptance. I'm talking about the thoughts that show up when a sensation hits or when you are activated or overstimulated, or in the middle of the night when your brain won't stop.

What if this means something is really wrong? What if this goes on forever? I can't do this forever. I can't live like this. I can't bear this. Those thoughts feel so true when you are in the middle of it, but here's the thing. You are bearing it. You're here, you're still going. So the question isn't whether or not you can bear it.

The question is, can you bear it a little better, a little differently? Can you bear it without adding the fight on top? Allowing means letting these thoughts be there without grabbing onto them, without spinning on them, without engaging. They show up and you do what you do with your symptoms and sensations.

You let them pass through. You do not have to believe them. You don't have to argue with them. You don't have to prove them wrong, you leave them alone. But to be clear, the primary focus of allowing is in the body. It is the relationship with the moment to moment sensations and symptoms. Thoughts are included, but they're not the main event here.

When a scary thought spikes, you do the same thing, allow it. You don't fight it. But mostly allowing is what's happening right now for me physically, what is my relationship to that, and can I create a better relationship with what I'm experiencing? Because I think we underestimate how much the negative relationship we have, relationship drives a continued experience of what we don't want.

Allowing also means allowing uncertainty, not knowing if this is gonna work, it might not work. Allow that thought, not knowing how long it's gonna take. I don't know if it's gonna take you two weeks or two years. Allow that thought. Not knowing if today's gonna be a good day or a bad day, which I would honestly encourage you to stop making those assessments.

Allowing means you move forward without needing those answers first. One thing that trips people up is treating, allowing, like it has an end point. Like, you're just gonna allow until things get better, or I'm gonna allow for two weeks, I'm gonna see if this works. Or allowing it as like a strategy to make symptoms go away faster using, allowing as a tool.

But that is not allowing, that's allowing with an agenda, with a, with a belief of where this needs to go. You don't have control over that. We just do wanna keep moving in the right direction, but we don't have control over how fast that happens, the moment you're checking to see if it's working or monitoring whether your symptoms are improving because you're allowing so well.

You're not allowing anymore. You're, you're back in the fight there. If allowing feels scary to you, that makes sense. Like when your brain has been fighting your symptoms for so long, stopping the fight is also going to feel dangerous because your brain has convinced you that fighting is what's keeping things from getting worse.

So if you stop, everything's gonna fall apart. The scariest part for me was the fear that things could get worse. And allowing meant leaning into uncertainty, giving up control, and embracing the possibility that things might get harder before they got easier. And when they did, I needed to allow them. But for most of us, the fear isn't really that allowing is going to hurt you.

The fear is that you won't be able to control the outcome. And that's one of the major things that has to shift here. There's a reason this lesson comes after acceptance because if you're still mentally fighting all day, you still believe that what you're experiencing shouldn't be happening then allowing is going to be impossible.

You cannot soften to sensations that you're resisting so strongly in your mind. So we soften mentally first, then we soften physically. Acceptance comes first and then allowing becomes possible for you. Here's what happens when you actually start allowing. Your relationship to your symptoms is gonna change.

So even if they are still there, they're not gonna feel. Or seem as threatening and you stop bracing against them all day, which is the excellent news about that, is you will be less exhausted. There is so much energy just being drained from the fight, which means you are gonna have more energy and more capacity.

And what does that give you the ability to respond even better. Your nervous system will begin to learn something new. It will learn that these sensations can be there. What do you know? Nothing catastrophic happens. It learns you don't have to do anything about them. It learns that they're not the emergency it thought they were over time.

This is what will lower your baseline. This is what desensitizes your system. So just like acceptance, allowing isn't something to do. It's what's left. When you stop the physical fighting, it's the byproduct of putting down the physical resistance. It's not about allowing better, it's about resisting less.

Which allows you to let it be there. It allows you to allow it. Understanding, allowing is one thing. Living it in real moments though is another. So in the next lesson, I wanna show you what allowing actually looks like in practice. What to do when a sensation spikes, how to spot when you're not really allowing, and how this works in ordinary moments throughout your day.